The actual landowning groups are described as the *Bumiputtirar*, otherwise called the *vellalar*. Historically they were locals and hence they were referred to as *nattu-makkal*. The communal assembly of this group is *Cittira Meli Periyanattar*.

Royal Officials

A band of officials executed the royal orders. The prime minister was uttara-mantri. The historical personalities like Manickavasagar, Kulaciraiyar and Marankari worked as ministers. The royal secretariat was known as *eluttu-mandapam*. The most respected officials were *maran-eyinan*, *sattan-ganapathy*, *enathi-sattan*, *tira-tiran*, *murthi-eyinan* and others. The titles of military commanders were *palli-velan, parantakan-palli-velan, maran-adittan* and *tennavan-tamilvel*.

Administrative Divisions

Pandy nadu, as in Chola state, consisted of many provinces known as *vala-nadus*, which, in turn, were divided into many *nadus* and *kurrams*. The administrative authorities of nadus were the nattars. Nadu and Kurram contained settlements, viz. *mangalam*, *nagaram*, *ur* and *kudi,* where different social groups inhabited.

Village Administration

An inscription from Manur (Tirunelveli district) dated A.D. (CE) 800 provides an account of village administration. It looks similar to the Chola's local governance that included village assemblies and committees. Both civil and military powers seem to have been vested in the same person.

Irrigation

The Pandya rulers created a number of irrigation sources. On either side of the rivers *Vaigai* and Tamiraparani, channels leading to the irrigation tanks were built. In Southern Tamilnadu, like the Cholas, Pandyas introduced the new irrigation technology. Irrigation works were done by local administrative bodies, local chiefs and officials. Repairs were mostly undertaken by local bodies. Sometimes, traders also dug out tanks for irrigation.

Religion

Pandyas extended patronage to vedic practices. Velvikkudi copper plates as well as inscriptional sources mention the rituals like Asvameda yaga, Hiranya garbha and Vajapeya yaga, conducted by every great Pandya king. The impartiality of rulers towards both Saivism and Vaishnavism is also made known in the invocatory portions of the inscriptions. Temples of both sects were patronised through land grant, tax exemption and renovation.

The great Saiva and Vaishnava saints (Nayanmaras and Alwars) combined contributed to the growth of Tamil literature and spiritual enlightenment. The period was marked by intense religious conflict. The Bhakti movement of the time prompted the heterodox scholars for a debate. Many instances of the defeat of Buddhists and Jains in such debates are mentioned in Bhakti literature. The Pandya kings of the period supported and promoted Tamil and Sanskrit.

Temples

Medieval Pandyas and later Pandyas did not build any new temples but maintained the existing temples, enlarging them with the addition of *gopuras*, and *mandapas*. The monolithic mega size ornamented pillars are the unique feature of the medieval Pandya style. The sculptures of Siva, Vishnu, Kotravai, Ganesa

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